religions

MDPI

*Review*

# Interreligious Dialogue, Conflict Resolution and Peacebuilding: A Review †

**Michael Daniel Driessen**

Department of Political Science and International Affairs, John Cabot University, 00152 Rome, Italy; mdriessen@johncabot.edu

† This paper draws on work that was previously published in *Pro Dialogo*, the journal produced by the Vatican's Dicastery for Interreligious Dialogue.

**Abstract:** Over the last twenty years, policymakers and practitioners have supported the growth of multiple interreligious initiatives aimed at peacebuilding and conflict resolution, and scholars have sought to understand and evaluate their efficiency. This article introduces and reviews the emerging scholarship which has developed to understand and analyze these efforts. It begins by drawing from recent empirical research to outline how scholars understand religion as being linked to conflicts and naming a number of initiatives that have been constructed as responses to them. The article then considers how interreligious dialogue could be understood to serve as a conduit for conflict mediation and peacebuilding. Finally, the paper discusses several persistent criticisms that have been raised about interreligious dialogue as a model of conflict resolution, especially in light of the ongoing wars in Ukraine and Gaza, and ends with some reflections about contemporary strategies for interreligious peacebuilding in light of them.

**Keywords:** interreligious engagement; conflict resolution; peacebuilding; religious violence; post-conflict reconstruction; Pope Francis; Marrakesh Declaration; Human Fraternity Document; Abraham Accords

check for updates

Academic Editor: Mohammed Abu-Nimer

Received: 18 November 2024
Revised: 7 January 2025
Accepted: 22 January 2025
Published: 28 January 2025

**Citation:** Driessen, Michael Daniel. 2025. Interreligious Dialogue, Conflict Resolution and Peacebuilding: A Review. *Religions* 16: 150. https://doi.org/10.3390/rel16020150

**Copyright:** © 2025 by the author. Licensee MDPI, Basel, Switzerland. This article is an open access article distributed under the terms and conditions of the Creative Commons Attribution (CC BY) license (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/).

## 1. Introduction

Over the last twenty years, policymakers and practitioners have supported the growth of multiple new interreligious peacemaking initiatives, and scholars have sought to understand and evaluate their efficiency (Merdjanova and Brodeur 2009; Bercovitch and Kadayifci-Orellana 2009; Abu-Nimer 2015; Hunter 2018; Abu-Nimer and Nelson 2021). In many ways, these efforts could be read as resulting from the "return of religion" to international relations and the critical shift, still in development, towards a "religious engagement" praxis within foreign policymaking, particularly in the West (Appleby et al. 2010; Mandaville and Silvestri 2015; Marshall 2021; Mandaville 2021; Petito et al. 2018, 2021; U.S. Agency for International Development 2023; Klocek 2024). This shift accelerated in the wake of the events of 9/11 and the widescale attention it brought to the role of religion in global politics. In response to what they perceived to be an increase in security threats linked to religion, policymakers sought new ways to engage with religious actors and communities in order to better prevent and mediate religiously expressed conflicts.

Security concerns, however, were not the whole story. There was also a growing awareness and sensitivity within international policymaking circles of the positive benefits of partnering with religious actors and communities on a wide range of shared humanitarian goals, including on economic development, poverty alleviation, migration and the environment (Thomas 2005; Abu-Nimer 2015; Marshall 2017). While accelerated by fears

about the growth of religiously expressed violence, therefore, this post-secular awareness in international relations was also the product of a new intellectual climate and the development of a range of sociological, philosophical and theological positions about the continued, positive and even necessary role of religion across contemporary societies (Barbato 2012; Mavelli and Petito 2012; Driessen 2023).

This article reflects on the role of interreligious dialogue in conflict resolution efforts that have emerged in this context. It begins by drawing from recent empirical research to outline several ways that scholars understand religion as being linked to conflicts and naming a number of initiatives that have been constructed as responses to them. The article then considers how interreligious dialogue could be understood to serve as a conduit for conflict mediation and peacebuilding. Finally, the paper discusses several persistent criticisms that have been raised about interreligious dialogue as a model of conflict resolution, especially in light of the ongoing conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza, and ends with some reflections about contemporary strategies for interreligious peacebuilding in light of them.

## 2. Religion, Conflict and Violence: Conflict Resolution Research

Before evaluating the claim that interreligious dialogue might help resolve or mediate conflicts, it is helpful to begin with what we know about the relationship between religion and conflicts more generally. The assumption (or hope) that interreligious dialogue might mediate a conflict results from the assumption that religion is somehow involved in or a cause of conflict. So how do scholars view religion as being linked to violent armed conflicts today? Recent empirical studies in the field of conflict resolution have confirmed a growing number of religiously expressed or religiously identified conflicts worldwide (Toft et al. 2011; Svensson and Nilsson 2018; Klocek and Hassner 2019; Deitch 2022). Using a variety of empirical measures, scholars have documented that there has been an increase in the number of conflicts which involve religious actors and ideas since the early 2000s; that these actors and ideas have been increasingly central (as opposed to peripheral) to conflicts; and that when this has occurred, conflicts have tended to last longer and—with some disagreement (see Deitch 2022)—to be associated with more deadly forms of violence (Toft et al. 2011; Toft and Zhukov 2015; Svensson and Nilsson 2018). Some, but not all, of these conflicts, it should be noted, are intrareligious in nature. This means that many religiously coded conflicts are fought between conflict parties from the same religion. There are also very different levels of conflict in which religion may be involved, from civil wars to inter-state wars to international, "extra-systemic" conflicts (Henne 2019). Finally, it is also important to remember that many conflicts which involve parties from two different religions are not fought over religious issues at all. Therefore, even where religion is involved in the conflict, it is always entangled in a web of other factors which could include economic insecurity or inequality, ethnic or political marginalization, international interference and vulnerable institutions, to name a few.

While scholars might agree on the apparent increase in religiously identified conflicts across the globe, there is no consensus on why religious conflicts have become more frequent over the last twenty years; the extent to which religious motivations actually cause or complicate a conflict; or how and why the addition of a more overt religious dimension to a conflict might shift its length or kind of violence. A critical body of scholarship has also questioned the extent to which the designation of a conflict as "religious" has been constructed and instrumentalized by modern nation-states to legitimize the use of their own "secular" violence (itself a constructed category) as a means to contain it (Asad 1999; Cavanaugh 2009; Omer 2023). Disentangling religious and non-religious causes from any

conflict situation, therefore, is a difficult if not impossible task, and scholarly analysis must proceed with caution.

As the number of religiously identified conflicts has grown, so too have religious and interreligious efforts at peacebuilding. Thus, during this same time period, groups like the International Dialogue Center (KAICIID, est. 2012), Adyan Foundation (est. 2006), the Network for Traditional and Religious Peacemakers (est. 2013), the Abu Dhabi Peace Forum (formerly the Forum for Promoting Peace in Muslim Societies, est. 2014) and the International Partnership on Religion and Development (est. 2016), among many others, were established. These new interreligious peacebuilding efforts added to those of pre-existing organizations and movements like Religions for Peace, the community of Sant'Eigido, Catholic Relief Services and others, who also renewed or developed new interfaith initiatives aimed at stemming the rising tide of religiously identified conflicts (Huda and Marshall 2013; Bolton 2018; Zucconi 2018; Klocek 2024).

These initiatives have mapped out a new field for interreligious peacemaking. They have targeted the various phases of conflict, including conflict prevention, conflict mediation and post-conflict reconstruction, and in various kinds of conflicts as well. The following section outlines several common ways that these and other organizations have employed dialogue in conflict resolution efforts. In doing so, it reflects on what their use reveals to us about how we understand and approach religiously identified conflicts as well as interreligious dialogue itself as, variously, an idea, method, project or tool.

## 3. The Tools of Interreligious Dialogue

Scholars have observed similar repertoires of action that religious peacebuilders have employed in conflict situations. Common religious peacebuilding efforts include facilitating Track II diplomacy; channeling and mobilizing non-violent civil society action; challenging political and social injustices; and accompanying post-conflict reconciliation processes (Toft et al. 2011; Omer et al. 2015; Abu-Nimer 2015). Interreligious efforts have incorporated all of these tools and more in their work at various stages of conflicts. The following sections consider some of these efforts.

### *3.1. Interreligious Dialogue and Conflict Prevention*

In the prevention stage of conflict, one major push has been for the creation of interfaith leadership councils or national interfaith platforms, including by organizations like Religious for Peace and KAICIID (Abu-Nimer et al. 2007; Bolton 2018; Williams 2023). The creation of such councils recognizes the important social and political influence that local religious authorities wield, especially in countries with high levels of religiosity. This is particularly the case in so-called developing countries with weakly institutionalized political structures or civil society. In these settings, as much work on religion and politics has recognized, religious communities often represent civil society organization or at least an important portion of it (Thomas 2005; Haynes 2009). Interreligious dialogue initiatives among religious leaders in any country, especially in a religiously divided country, can serve to build bridges of trust and reciprocity among religious authorities who can then employ their influence to diffuse social and political tensions that may otherwise escalate into armed conflict (Merdjanova and Brodeur 2009; Bartoli and Garofalo 2018; Berlingozzi 2024; Raineri 2024). In this vein, for example, recent work by Berlingozzi (2024) and Raineri (2024) has examined the capacity and risks of dialogues among traditional religious authorities within the Sahel region aimed at building social resilience.

These councils and networks of traditional religious authorities also offer a readily identifiable interreligious infrastructure which policymakers can call on in times of tense interreligious relations. In this way, the councils might be part of wider interreligious

efforts to "manage" internal religious diversity (Körs and Nagel 2018) in both organic ways and in partnership with state-run institutions. Although the causal relationship between religious pluralism and religious conflict has been notoriously difficult to establish (Henne 2019; Klocek and Hassner 2019), these initiatives often assume that managing religious pluralism can act as a preventative force against the politicization and polarization of religious differences and the negative and even violent consequences that such polarization may entail (Bercovitch and Kadayifci-Orellana 2009; Kadayifci-Orellana 2013; Silvestri and Mayall 2015; Hunter 2018).

Similarly, interreligious action strategies have paid much attention to the role of healthy religious education programming in preventing armed interreligious conflicts from occurring (Abu-Nimer and Smith 2016; Santoso and Khisbiyah 2021). Revising educational curricula so that they do not inculcate harmful stereotypes of religious others or repropose religiously justified narratives of exclusion or hate has been seen to be critical for overcoming social divisions at the heart of many armed conflicts (Driessen et al. 2020). More broadly speaking, these and other initiatives seek to construct mutually reinforcing bonds of trust and solidarity among religious communities and diverse religious individuals. They also aim to generate religiously inclusive national narratives, built on an idea of unity-in-diversity, which repropose religious plurality as a source of national pride rather than division.

In related ways, interreligious initiatives have participated in preventing and countering violent extremism programs (PVE/CVE) which seek to intervene in the process of the radicalization of youth and other vulnerable individuals. In order to do so, interreligious organizations have offered a range of resources, training exercises and workshops aimed at delegitimizing religious narratives of violence. These programs do so by deconstructing exclusivist narratives and offering a counternarrative, based on appeals to religious authority and tradition, that the true aim of their religious call and system of belief is to peace, compassion, mercy, moderation and restraint (Abu-Nimer and Smith 2016; Santoso and Khisbiyah 2021).

The following section will raise a number of critiques that point to the limits of this and other interreligious approaches. Suffice it to note here that any attempt at deconstructing religious narratives raises thorny questions about who has religious authority over the "authentic" interpretation of any religious message (Omer 2023). Countering or preventing violent extremism programs are also often sponsored or financed by state actors and connected to state attempts to "securitize" potential religious threats through enhanced government surveillance and scrutiny (Körs and Nagel 2018). These efforts create a classic carrot and sticks dilemma, making it difficult for religious actors to understand whether the encouragement to moderate one's religious message can be trusted to be in the interests of their religious community, especially when it occurs in contexts of social or governmental discrimination. This has led to skepticism of a number of these projects.

Finally, at a higher level of conflict prevention, interreligious actors have engaged in efforts to sustain a "Dialogue among Civilizations" in order to prevent what Samuel Huntington feared could be a looming "Clash of Civilizations" (Kayaoglu 2012; Driessen 2023). One of Huntington's (1993) central claims was that international conflict among diverse civilizational orders (which he identified with major global religious traditions) and the states which represented them was likely to occur because of a basic incommensurability when it comes to political and social values, especially with respect to democracy and human rights. Through UN programs like the UN Alliance of Civilizations and high-level interreligious dialogues and declarations like the 2005 A Common Word letter, the 2018 Nusantara Manifesto and the 2019 Document on Human Fraternity, religious authorities,

scholars and civil society members have attempted to identify common values rooted in their traditions which could jointly promote civilization cooperation rather than conflict.

### 3.2. Interreligious Dialogue and Conflict Mediation

Once the prevention stage of a conflict has been surpassed and the conflict has escalated to violent, armed struggle, new interreligious considerations come into play. Many of the interreligious tools employed in this phase of the conflict build on those used in interreligious conflict prevention. Religious communities, thus, may resist calls to violence against their fellow, otherly religious citizens or mobilize for non-violent civil society action in the face of religiously justified violence (Day 2021). Likewise, interreligious councils and religious leaders might publicly denounce violence in the name of religion (Brodeur 2020; Mokrani 2022). The bonds of trust and reciprocity that these communities and leaders have built during peacetime might make such denouncements more likely, more credible and more effective.

An example here could be the Open Letter to Al-Baghdadi, written by a senior group of Muslim religious leaders in 2014 following the rise to power of the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria (ISIS). The letter deconstructs the religious arguments adopted by the Islamic State to justify their violent offensive war and their treatment of religious minorities and civilians. Notably, the letter would lead to further action by a number of the signatories, including the development of the Marrakesh Declaration in 2016. The Marrakesh Declaration brought together leading Muslim religious authorities and interreligious leaders who penned a strong declaration which denounced violence against religious minorities. In writing the letter, these actors understood religiously justified violence to require religious legitimacy from religious authorities in order to sustain itself. Interreligious peace efforts like the Marrakesh Declaration, or the 2022 Volos Declaration issued to condemn the Russian Orthodox Church's "Russian World" Teaching that justified the invasion of Ukraine, seek to take that authority away.

The theme of non-violence and "never again war" in the name of religion has been an important element of major, recent, interreligious efforts, including the 1993 Global Ethic and the 2009 Charter for Compassion. Drawing on the "golden rule" common to many religious traditions, for example, the Charter for Compassion states that, "any interpretation of scripture that breeds violence, hatred, or disdain is illegitimate" (Marsden 2018) and the Global Ethic declares a commitment to a "culture of non-violence" as the first of its "irrevocable directives". Similarly, in the Catholic Church, Pope Francis has repeatedly argued that war and violence are anathema to all religions (Appleby 2023). In his 2020 encyclical, *Fratelli Tutti*, he argued that the conditions regulating traditional Catholic understandings of just war theories no longer held because modern technologies had "granted war an uncontrollable destructive power over great numbers of innocent civilians" (FT241). At the same time, religious authorities have drawn on traditional doctrines of restraint to minimize violence once it has begun. Hence, Pope Francis has also acknowledged the legitimate right to self-defense in both Ukraine and Israel–Palestine. Pope Francis' secretary of state, Cardinal Pietro Parolin, has also used the just war criteria of proportionality to urge restraint in these conflicts (Tornielli and Cetera 2023; Smytsnyuk 2023).

Interreligious leaders have also been involved in Track II peace mediation efforts or have led such efforts themselves (Toft et al. 2011; Kronish 2017). The work of the community of Sant'Egidio has often been named in this regard (Zucconi 2018), but the examples of the Muhammadiyah movement's efforts to help mediate the conflict in the Mindanao (Anam and Surwandono 2013) or Nahdlatul Ulama's efforts in Afghanistan (Mahfudin and Sundrijo 2021) could also be cited. In these settings, religious leaders sometimes possess an unusual combination of social credibility, moral authority, symbolic resources,

political imagination and transnational networks of aid that can be effective in prodding and inviting warring parties to reimagine what is possible for a shared future.

Of course, just like in conflict prevention, religious efforts at peace mediation seldom if ever represent a magic solution. If, as is likely, the conflict between two religious parties began or continued for a complex mix of issues—including economic inequalities, scarce resources, ethnic marginalization or insecure borders to name just a few—then that entails that there are limits to what any interreligious conflict mediation process may achieve. And often interreligious mediators lack the skills or resources to accompany the substantial, multi-staged dimensions that a conflict mediation process may require, from constitutional design, to policing disarmament procedures, to the building of economically just welfare policies. Delegitimizing religiously justified violence may be important in conflict mediation, but so too will be responding to the political and economic drivers of the conflict. At best, therefore, interreligious leadership and communities may play a part in the mediation process by lending or leveraging their moral authority for it and accompanying the mediation process or endowing it with spiritual urgency and dynamism. However they proceed, it is clear that they will need help.

### 3.3. Post-Conflict Reconstruction

Like conflict prevention, and unlike conflict mediation, the post-conflict reconstruction phase of a conflict seems to offer more possibilities for interreligious action and support. Some of the specific resources that religious actors possess seem to come particularly into play at this stage. Hence, interreligious actors have been seen to facilitate processes of reconciliation as well as deploy deep reserves of symbolic resources and values and practices built up over centuries to enable intersocial and interpersonal processes of healing (Toft et al. 2011; Philpott 2015; Phan 2016; Pinzón 2020). The example of the South African Truth and Reconciliation is often viewed in this light. The Truth and Reconciliation Commission, led by Anglican Archbishop Desmond Tutu, drew on multi-religious ideas about restorative justice, reconciliation and social healing, which helped to build an inclusive vision of South Africa's political future. Among other things, the Commission confronted exclusionist theological narratives among South African churches which had supported Apartheid (Meiring 2003) and its results were recognized by a plurality of South African citizens (Gibson 2006). Other similar examples of confronting exclusionist narratives include efforts by religious and interreligious actors across the Arab world to draft a Charter for Inclusive Citizenship and Nahdlatul Ulama's efforts to promote a vision of Humanitarian Islam as a response to religiously legitimized violence in the region (Wilton Park 2021; The Nusantara Manifesto 2018; Driessen 2023).

Critically, religious communities can work together to live in their diversity well (Haddad and Fischbach 2015; Marshall 2017; Abu-Nimer 2020). Their ideas can powerfully shape visions of what durable peace might look like, setting an ideal of the common good which is inclusive of religious diversity and invites multi-religious cooperation (Driessen 2023). In so doing, they can rebuild the social cohesion and solidarity necessary to make forms of social interaction and cooperation among formerly warring parties possible again (Bolton 2018).

Here, a number of scholars and practitioners have reflected on the ability of interreligious dialogue to serve as a means for social and conflict transformation (Abu-Nimer et al. 2007; Bolton 2018; Schmid 2017; Neufeldt 2011; Hrynkow and Power 2018). In this approach, dialogue, as a method or tool, itself favors processes of mutual learning that can lead to enhanced and reciprocal understanding, healing, tolerance and trust. As an exercise, dialogue creates a certain personal, religious or social posture which primes participants towards open forms of communication and discovery (Schmid 2017; Hedges 2016). Drawing

on the work of Raimon Pannikar, for example, Abu-Nimer et al. (2007) reflect on dialogue as a religious experience of discovery and emancipation. Discovery-through-dialogue can entail identifying and understanding patterns of past grievances and overcoming them with a jointly created identity of reconciliation where a new, shared truth emerges. A number of interreligious dialogue initiatives have adopted transparent statements of their "theory of change" for their programs in order to name how they see such transformation processes occurring. Catholic Relief Services (Bolton 2018), for example, formulated their "Theory of Change of Interreligious Peacebuilding" as follows:

"If local faith communities and their leaders, including Muslims, Christians and other cultural groups, engage in personal healing, rebuild internal group cohesion, and participate in intergroup dialogue, training and practical initiatives to meet shared needs, then, over time, mutual understanding, tolerance and trust will be enhanced because healing, reconciliation, joint decision-making and action present opportunities for positive interactions that can break down stereotypes and hostility, contributing to peace and security".

## 4. Critiques

A number of important critiques have been raised about the assumptions undergirding some of the initiatives reviewed above. One persistent criticism has been that many of these initiatives, but especially those targeting or leveraging the moral authority of interreligious leadership, problematically skirt over questions of political power and religious authority. At a basic level, including certain religious actors into (multi) religious peacebuilding efforts could be seen to legitimize the authority and ideas of those religious actors. Religious authorities may involve themselves in processes of mediation precisely for this reason, particularly when political authorities are also involved (Fahy 2018a). Recognizing the potential of religious authorities to resolve a conflict somehow already transfers social authority to them and may institutionalize that authority over time, even if those authorities may be complicit in the issues which started the conflict in the first place.

All of this raises immediate questions about instrumentalization, regarding both the instrumentalization of political power by religious authorities, as well as the instrumentalization of religious communities and ideas by the state (Kayaoglu 2015; Wolff 2017; Yilmaz and Barry 2020; Driessen 2023). Instrumentalization can be exacerbated the more that long-term multi-religious structures are built up and institutionalized by governing authorities (Griera and Nagel 2018). As I have argued elsewhere, the institutionalization of a range of interreligious councils and initiatives has served an important role in creating partnerships for the common good between religious actors and policymakers (Driessen 2023; Petito et al. 2021). These very same institutions could also be seen to serve as a sort of proto-ministry of religious affairs for the international community, with all of the potential for state management, domestication and control of religious actors that go along with it (Wolff 2017). Dialogue activities may also serve some states as tools of propaganda and useful distractions from their authoritarian policies and projects, as a number of scholars have criticized Gulf states like Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the UAE (Wolff 2017; Fahy 2018b; al-Azami 2019).

In a similar way, as Elizabeth Shakman Hurd (2015) has argued, these initiatives often elevate Big "R" Religion—the official, formal structures of religious authority who are not necessary benign actors—at the expense of little "r" religion—the lived religion of everyday religious citizens and their myriad struggles for justice, equality, freedom and recognition. In doing so, as Omer (2023) has argued, interreligious dialogue initiatives have often disempowered local religious actors and knowledge. The interreligious dialogue peace nexus, in Omer's analysis, is itself a product of Western humanitarian ideas and practices, often to the detriment of local moral economies (Autesserre 2014). By elevating

Big "R" Religion, interreligious initiatives can also be seen to reinforce certain neocolonial and patriarchal structures of religious power embedded within it. This has particularly been argued with respect to gender equality (Marshall 2010). State-sponsored interreligious dialogue initiatives often prize engagement with formal religious authorities in conflict zones, who are often male representatives of religious organizations, and elevate their authority in doing so.

At the same time, excluding these religious actors might make the dialogue less effective (Patton 2018). As I have also argued elsewhere, one of the reasons religious authorities may participate in dialogue processes in the first place is that they perceive them to be consonant with some project of religious renewal, one which is more or less in line with an orthodox religious reading of their traditions (Driessen 2023; Sopyan et al. 2020). They are, usually explicitly so, against any project that feels like it might facilitate religious relativism, syncretism or challenges to core traditional beliefs. In other words, many traditional religious leaders, who may have real moral authority in any given conflict setting, are unlikely to participate in processes explicitly designed to emancipate or transform their religious belief systems.

Hurd (2015) and Omer's (2023) critiques, therefore, highlight an important tension between the various goals, aspirations and "theories of change" of interreligious initiatives and also reveal something important about how we think about interreligious dialogue as a process in and of itself. This tension divides more minimal versions of interreligious peacemaking from more normatively substantive, "transformative" ones (Driessen 2020). In the more minimal version, religious or social transformation is not required or necessary. Interreligious dialogue and interreligious leadership councils and much of the structure of interreligious peacebuilding is simply built up to facilitate interreligious cooperation and prevent interreligious conflict. The risk in this version of interreligious peacebuilding is that it likely leaves some religious framings which facilitate social injustices untouched. Religious and social narratives in favor of violence may remain unreconstructed and, therefore, legitimized.

That is where transformative interreligious peacebuilding steps in, by arguing that some form of emancipation is necessary to get at the root problems of conflict and overcome them in the service of universal values (Knitter 2013). But as I began to hint above, the religious actors who might be most in need of participating in religious peacebuilding efforts might be those more resistant to change in the first place, or the most sensitive to perceptions of outside and foreign threats, or they might have different ideas about what counts as a universal value.

A number of theories of change, therefore, may overestimate the transformative power of dialogue and the consensus about the content that any such transformation might be working towards. Many interreligious efforts, for example, espouse a range of more or less agreed upon international humanitarian goals, including advancing human rights, advocating for environmental change, protecting migrants and refugees and achieving sustainable development goals. And yet, it is not clear that mainstream religious traditions across the globe would fully ascribe to this entire package of values as a vision of religious or political emancipation. Once again, the question of religious authority must be raised. If interreligious dialogue is meant to be transformative, who is the final authority on what that transformation should look like? And what if the religious authorities do not agree with major components of that transformation process?

Additionally, at least empirically, we cannot entirely discard the alternative hypothesis that Huntington's (1993) arguments suggest, namely that interreligious dialogue may, at least in some cases, exacerbate interreligious conflict as much as it overcomes it by reaffirming rather than easing stereotypes about the Other. Globalization might have

brought the world closer to each other, but it has also retrenched exclusivist identity positions among many communities seeking to protect their roots and traditions from foreign values assumed to be universal. It is partly for this reason that scholars of dialogue speak about the "necessary conditions" for dialogue to occur (Schmid 2017).

Finally, a number of critics have questioned the effectiveness of interreligious engagement in light of the continued or worsening violence committed in the name of religion (Wolff 2017; Markiewicz 2018). This is a particularly relevant criticism with regard to the wars in Gaza and Ukraine. In both cases, a bitter sense of failure has cast a pall over decades of what appeared to be successful interfaith breakthroughs in both Eastern Europe—between the Catholic and Russian Orthodox Churches—and the Middle East—between Muslim, Jewish and Christian authorities and communities. For years, the Vatican and the Russian Orthodox Church had worked to overcome historical animosity between the churches. Building on the efforts and relationships of both Pope John Paul II and Pope Benedict XVI with Moscow Patriarchs Alexy II and Kirill, Pope Francis became the first pope to meet the Moscow Patriarch in 2016, in Cuba, where he signed the Havana Declaration with Patriarch Kirill. Pope Francis' papacy was marked by similar breakthroughs in interreligious dialogue with the Muslim majority world, as evidenced by the 2019 Human Fraternity Document signed with the Grand Imam of Al Azhar, Ahmed al Tayeb, during the first papal visit to the Arabian Peninsula, and his visit to the Grand Ayatollah al Sistani in Najaf, Iraq, in 2021. In the run-up to the Abraham Accords, prominent Jewish–Muslim dialogue efforts were also taken through initiatives like the Abu Dhabi Peace Forum, which brought together prominent Jewish scholars through its Alliance of Virtue project; the Abrahamic Family House project, which built a prominent new synagogue–church–mosque complex in the UAE in 2023; and the visits of the Muslim World League's Secretary General, Mohammad al Issa, to both the United States Holocaust Museum (2018) and Auschwitz (2020).

The cusp of what seemed to be a new dawn of interreligious cooperation in both regions now appears in a dramatically changed light. In either case, major interreligious efforts did not prevent the renewal of armed conflict and have not been able to successfully mediate in the conflicts either. In both cases, dialogue efforts have been accused of being instrumentalized by exclusivist political agendas. Hovorun (2023), for example, has argued that the Russian Orthodox Church has effectively hijacked ecumenical dialogue platforms to promote and legitimize Russian propaganda about the war in Ukraine. Likewise, Raheb (2023) and Omer (2023) have argued that interreligious dialogue initiatives in the region have served to shield Israel from criticism of its settlement policies and treatment of Palestinians in Gaza and the West Bank, and that it led the Abraham Accords to totally ignore the Palestinian question with devastating results. All of this has raised renewed scrutiny of the capacity of interreligious peacebuilding efforts as a project moving forward, even when religion is not the only or key factor driving the onset of violence, as in both the Ukraine and Gaza conflicts.

## 5. Reflections and Conclusions

While varying in their level of critique, it is interesting to note that none of these criticisms fully argue against interreligious dialogue. They might be seen, therefore, as inviting dialogue practitioners, scholars and leaders to a kind of purification of their practices in order to conduct dialogue better, to adopt a stance of "religious social responsibility" and to evaluate the extent to which their work contributes to the construction of a just and inclusive peace (Hovorun 2023; Raheb 2023; Daou Forthcoming). At some level, many dialogue practitioners are aware of the risks involved in their work, or are trying to learn more about them, and they have sought ways to minimize any harm linked to their activity. The task of

peacebuilding and mediation between religious groups in conflict, as the first part of this essay reviewed, leaves little other option than to enter into a dialogue of some kind with religious others, including, especially, with one's "religious enemies". Mercy, love, reconciliation, compassion—the spiritual tools animating interreligious peacebuilding—always require dialogue of some kind with the "Other".

By way of conclusion, I would like to suggest that these critiques could also be seen as helping to liberate dialogue from overloaded expectations and refocus attention on the actual content and efforts and possibilities at hand. As Pasquale Ferrara (2023) has noted, religion is not always necessarily the cause or the solution to a conflict, but it is often simply part of the process, a contributing factor that diplomats and practitioners need to understand and engage with, but not over-essentialize either.

In terms of policy analysis, this might be understood as a counsel for modesty. For example, it is important to distinguish between different sets of specific dialogue movements as opposed to one master dialogue project. Different movements and different experiences have built up shared resources which have contributed to peace processes and, in doing so, navigated these risks in a variety of ways. Empirically, it is helpful to simply map these projects out and evaluate and learn from them over time.

It is also helpful to observe that many of the conflict resolution possibilities associated with religious actors and communities are linked to long-run developments as opposed to short-term solutions. While religious leaders may have a role to play in denouncing violence in the immediate heat of battle, they are likely to have a more lasting impact on conflict (and its absence) through their capacity to generate and sustain life-giving visions of a peaceful society and mobilize communities for collective action in favor of them. Recent interreligious declarations in the Middle East calling for the development of inclusive citizenship and human fraternity are important examples in this regard (Petito et al. 2021; Driessen 2023). By appealing for spiritual solidarity, for religious social responsibility, for religious freedom and pluralism lived well, interreligious leaders can challenge the conflict at hand, appeal to society as a whole and set a credible, post-conflict vision of a durable peace. This will also require drawing on interreligious practices and experiences from within society, which may serve as models of pluralism to build on. In this way, interreligious leaders and communities may engage together in a more comprehensive model of peacebuilding which serves and constructs peace over time.

**Funding:** This research received no external funding.

**Data Availability Statement:** No new data were created or analyzed in this study. Data sharing is not applicable to this article.

**Conflicts of Interest:** The author declares no conflict of interest.

## References

Abu-Nimer, Mohammed. 2015. Religion and peacebuilding: Reflections on current challenges and future prospects. *Journal of Interreligious Studies* 16: 13–29.

Abu-Nimer, Mohammed. 2020. Interreligious dialogue and the path to reconciliation. In *Multi-Level Reconciliation and Peacebuilding*. London and New York: Routledge.

Abu-Nimer, Mohammed, Amal Khoury, and Emily Welty. 2007. *Unity in Diversity: Interfaith Dialogue in the Middle East*. Washington, DC: US Institute of Peace Press.

Abu-Nimer, Mohammed, and Renata Kaitlin Nelson, eds. 2021. *Evaluating Interreligious Peacebuilding and Dialogue: Methods and Frameworks*. Boston: De Gruyter.

Abu-Nimer, Mohammed, and Renata Kaitlin Smith. 2016. Interreligious and intercultural education for dialogue, peace and social cohesion. *International Review of Education* 62: 393–405. [CrossRef]

al-Azami, Usaama A. 2019. 'Abdullāh bin Bayyah and the Arab revolutions: Counter-revolutionary neo-traditionalism's ideological struggle against Islamism. *Muslim World* 109: 343–61. [CrossRef]

Anam, Muhammad Zahrul, and S. Surwandono. 2013. *NGOs and Peacebuilding in the Philippines: Muhammadiyah's Reconstruction Plan for the Bangsamoro Post Peace Agreement*. Yogyakarta: Universitas Muhammadiyah Yogyakarta.

Appleby, R. Scott. 2023. Engaging Religions for the Common Good: Pope Francis' Radical Peacebuilding Proposition. In *Religion and Peacebuilding in Contemporary Global Crises*. Edited by Fabio Petito and Michael D. Driessen. Milan: Italian Institute for International Political Studies (ISPI).

Appleby, R. Scott, Richard Cizik, and Thomas Wright. 2010. *Engaging Religious Communities Abroad: A New Imperative for US Foreign Policy*. Chicago: Chicago Council on Global Affairs.

Asad, Talal. 1999. Religion, nation-state, secularism. In *Nation and Religion: Perspectives on Europe and Asia*. Edited by P. van der Veer and Hartmut Lehmann. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Autesserre, Séverine. 2014. *Peaceland: Conflict Resolution and the Everyday Politics of International Intervention*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Barbato, Mariano. 2012. Postsecular Revolution: Religion after the End of History. *Review of International Studies* 28: 1079–97. [CrossRef]

Bartoli, Andrea, and Mauro Garofalo. 2018. Prevention through Political Agreements. In *Preventing Mass Atrocities: Policies and Practices*. Edited by Barbara Harff and Ted Robert Gurr. London and New York: Routledge.

Bercovitch, Jacob, and S. Ayse Kadayifci-Orellana. 2009. Religion and mediation: The role of faith-based actors in international conflict resolution. *International Negotiation* 14: 175–204. [CrossRef]

Berlingozzi, Laura. 2024. *Sahelian Dialogues: The Path to Resilience through Religious and Traditional Authority*. Working Paper. Pisa: Sant'Anna School of Advanced Studies.

Bolton, Nell, ed. 2018. *Interreligious Action for Peace: Studies in Muslim-Christian Cooperation*. Baltimore: Catholic Relief Services.

Brodeur, Patrice. 2020. Insights: Building Bridges: Global Peacebuilding Efforts. In *Faith, Identity, Cohesion: Building a Better Future*. Singapore: World Scientific, pp. 221–33.

Cavanaugh, William T. 2009. The myth of religious violence. In *The Blackwell Companion to Religion and Violence*. Hoboken: John Wiley & Sons, pp. 23–33.

Daou, Fadi. Forthcoming. Dialogue beyond Borders. From Dialogue to Interreligious Engagement. *Religion and Development* 3.

Day, Joel. 2021. Everyday practices of toleration: The interfaith foundations of peace accords in Sierra Leone. *Politics and Religion* 14: 54–82. [CrossRef]

Deitch, Mora. 2022. Is religion a barrier to peace? Religious influence on violent intrastate conflict termination. *Terrorism and Political Violence* 34: 1454–70. [CrossRef]

Driessen, Michael Daniel. 2020. Evaluating Interreligious Dialogue in the Middle East. *Peace Review* 32: 1–12. [CrossRef]

Driessen, Michael Daniel. 2023. *The Global Politics of Interreligious Dialogue: Religious Change, Citizenship, and Solidarity in the Middle East*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Driessen, Michael Daniel, Anna Maria Daou, Dima Karadsheh, Neira Omerovic, and Faris Ilyas Keti. 2020. *Interreligious Dialogue Mapping of the Middle East: Lebanon, Jordan, Turkey and Iraq*. Beirut: Adyan Foundation Institute of Citizenship and Diversity Management and Rashad Center for Cultural Governance.

Fahy, John. 2018a. International Relations and Faith-based Diplomacy: The Case of Qatar. *The Review of Faith and International Affairs* 16: 76–88. [CrossRef]

Fahy, John. 2018b. The international politics of tolerance in the Persian Gulf. *Religion, State & Society* 46: 311–27.

Ferrara, Pasquale. 2023. Religion, Conflict and Peacebuilding: A Diplomatic Perspective. In *Religion and Peacebuilding in Contemporary Global Crises*. Edited by Fabio Petito and Michael Daniel Driessen. Milan: Italian Institute for International Political Studies (ISPI).

Gibson, James L. 2006. The contributions of truth to reconciliation: Lessons from South Africa. *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 50: 409–32. [CrossRef]

Griera, Mar, and Alexander-Kenneth Nagel. 2018. Interreligious relations and governance of religion in Europe: Introduction. *Social Compass* 65: 301–11. [CrossRef]

Haddad, Yvonne Yazbeck, and Rahel Fischbach. 2015. Interfaith dialogue in Lebanon: Between a power balancing act and theological encounters. *Islam and Christian–Muslim Relations* 26: 423–42. [CrossRef]

Haynes, Jeffrey. 2009. Conflict, conflict resolution and peace-building: The role of religion in Mozambique, Nigeria and Cambodia. *Commonwealth & Comparative Politics* 47: 52–75.

Hedges, Paul. 2016. Gadamer, Play, and Interreligious Dialogue as the Opening of Horizons. *Journal of Dialogue Studies* 4: 5–26. [CrossRef]

Henne, Peter. 2019. Terrorism and religion: An overview. In *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Hovorun, Cyril. 2023. Can "Ecumenism as Usual" be Possible in the Wake of the War in Ukraine. *Ecumenical Ends* 52: 25–31.

Hrynkow, Christopher, and Maria Power. 2018. Transforming the Center: Inter-Religious Dialogue, Contemporary Popes, and a Faith-Inspired Path for Peacebuilding. *International Journal of Peace Studies* 23: 5.

Huda, Qamar-ul, and Katherine Marshall. 2013. Integrated Peacebuilding: Innovative Approaches to Transforming Conflict. In *Integrated Peacebuilding*. Edited by Craig Zelizer. London and New York: Routledge.

Hunter, Shireen. 2018. How Effective is Interfaith Dialogue as an Instrument for Bridging International Differences and Achieving Conflict Resolution? *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 16: 102–13.
Huntington, Samuel P. 1993. The clash of civilizations. *Foreign Affairs* 72: 22–49. [CrossRef]
Hurd, Elizabeth Shakman. 2015. *Beyond Religious Freedom: The New Global Politics of Religion*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
Kadayifci-Orellana, S. Ayse. 2013. Inter-Religious Dialogue and Peacebuilding. In *The Wiley-Blackwell Companion to Inter-Religious Dialogue*. Hoboken: John Wiley & Sons, pp. 149–67.
Kayaoglu, Turan. 2012. Constructing the dialogue of civilizations in world politics: A case of global Islamic activism. *Islam and Christian–Muslim Relations* 23: 129–47. [CrossRef]
Kayaoglu, Turan. 2015. Explaining interfaith dialogue in the Muslim world. *Politics and Religion* 8: 236–62. [CrossRef]
Klocek, Jason. 2024. *Strategic Religious Engagement in Peace Processes*. Washington, DC: United States Institute of Peace.
Klocek, Jason, and Ronald E. Hassner. 2019. War and religion: An overview. In *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics*. New York: Oxford University Press.
Knitter, Paul F. 2013. Inter-Religious Dialogue and Social Action. In *The Wiley-Blackwell Companion to Inter-Religious Dialogue*. Hoboken: John Wiley & Sons, pp. 133–48.
Körs, Anna, and Alexander-Kenneth Nagel. 2018. Local 'formulas of peace': Religious diversity and state-interfaith governance in Germany. *Social Compass* 65: 346–62. [CrossRef]
Kronish, Ronald. 2017. *The Other Peace Process: Interreligious Dialogue, a View from Jerusalem*. Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield.
Mahfudin, Irvan Aladip, and Dwi Ardhanariswari Sundrijo. 2021. Faith-Based Transnational Actors and Peacebuilding: An Analysis of the Role Of Nahdlatul Ulama in Afghanistan's Peace Process. *Global: Jurnal Politik Internasional* 23: 26–50. [CrossRef]
Mandaville, Peter. 2021. Right-Sizing Religion and Religious Engagement in Diplomacy and Development. *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 19: 92–97.
Mandaville, Peter, and Sara Silvestri. 2015. Integrating religious engagement into diplomacy: Challenges and opportunities. *Issues in Governance Studies* 67: 1–13.
Markiewicz, Sarah. 2018. Interfaith on the World Stage: Much Ado About Nothing? *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 16: 89–101.
Marsden, Lee. 2018. The golden rule: Interfaith peacemaking and the charter for compassion. *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 16: 61–75.
Marshall, Katherine. 2010. Development, religion, and women's roles in contemporary societies. *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 8: 35–42.
Marshall, Katherine. 2017. *Interfaith Journeys: An Exploration of History, Ideas, and Future Directions*. Washington, DC: World Faiths Development Dialogue, vol. 23.
Marshall, Katherine. 2021. Impressions & Indications of Religious Engagement in Development. *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 19: 12–30.
Mavelli, Luca, and Fabio Petito. 2012. The postsecular in International Relations: An overview. *Review of International Studies* 38: 931–42. [CrossRef]
Meiring, Piet. 2003. The Dutch Reformed Church and the Truth and Reconciliation Commission. *Scriptura* 83: 250–57. [CrossRef]
Merdjanova, Ina, and Patrice Brodeur. 2009. *Religion as a Conversation Starter: Interreligious Dialogue for Peacebuilding in the Balkans*. New York: Continuum.
Mokrani, Adnane. 2022. *Toward an Islamic Theology of Nonviolence: In Dialogue with René Girard*. East Lansing: MSU Press.
Neufeldt, Reina C. 2011. Interfaith dialogue: Assessing theories of change. *Peace & Change* 36: 344–72.
Omer, Atalia. 2023. *Decolonizing Religion and Peacebuilding*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
Omer, Atalia, R. Scott Appleby, and David Little, eds. 2015. *The Oxford Handbook of Religion, Conflict, and Peacebuilding*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
Patton, James. 2018. Including the Exclusivists in Interfaith. *The Review of Faith & International Affairs* 16: 23–33.
Petito, Fabio, Fadi Daou, and Michael Daniel Driessen. 2021. *Human Fraternity & Inclusive Citizenship: Interreligious Engagement in the Mediterranean*. Milano: Ledizioni.
Petito, Fabio, Stepahnie Berry, and Maria Mancinelli. 2018. *Interreligious Engagement Strategies. A Policy Tool to Advance Freedom of Religion or Belief*. Brighton: University of Sussex FoRB and Foreign Policy Initiative.
Phan, Peter C. 2016. Peacekeeping, peacemaking, peacebuilding: An interreligious spirituality for just peace. In *Violence, Religion, Peacemaking*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan, pp. 21–60.
Philpott, Daniel. 2015. *Just and Unjust Peace: An Ethic of Political Reconciliation*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
Pinzón, Orlando Solano. 2020. Peacebuilding like a tuner of interreligious dialogue in Colombia. *Franciscanum. Revista de las Ciencias del Espíritu* 62: 10.
Raheb, Mitri. 2023. *Decolonizing Palestine: The Land, the People, the Bible*. Ossining: Orbis Books.
Raineri, Luca. 2024. Religious dialogues, community resilience and peacebuilding in the Sahel. In *Policy Brief*. Pisa: Sant'Anna School of Advanced Studies.

Santoso, M. Abdual Fattah, and Yayah Khisbiyah. 2021. Islam-based peace education: Values, program, reflection and implication. *Indonesian Journal of Islam and Muslim Societies* 11: 185–207. [CrossRef]

Schmid, Hansjörg. 2017. Dialogue in Conflict–Conflict in Dialogue. Unexpected loci of Interreligious Theology. *Studies in Interreligious Dialogue* 27: 95–115.

Silvestri, Sara, and James Mayall. 2015. *The Role of Religion in Conflict and Peacebuilding*. Kawaguchi: British Academy.

Smytsnyuk, Pavlo. 2023. The Holy See Confronts the War in Ukraine between Just War Theory and Nonviolence. *Journal of the European Society for Catholic Theology* 14: 3–24.

Sopyan, Imam, Pepen Irpan Fauzan, and Ahmad Khoirul Fata. 2020. Religious Harmony, Godly Nationalism, and the Limits of State-sponsored Interreligious Dialogue Agenda in Indonesia. *Islamika Inside: Jurnal Keislaman dan Humaniora* 6: 31–53. [CrossRef]

Svensson, Isak, and Desirée Nilsson. 2018. Disputes over the divine: Introducing the religion and armed conflict (relac) data, 1975 to 2015. *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 62: 1127–48. [CrossRef]

The Nusantara Manifesto. 2018. *Nahdlatul Ulama*. Yogyakarta: Gerakan Pemuda Ansor and Bayt ar Rahmah.

Thomas, Scott. 2005. *The Global Resurgence of Religion and the Transformation of International Relations: The Struggle for the Soul of the Twenty-First Century*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Toft, Monica Duffy, and Yuri M. Zhukov. 2015. Islamists and nationalists: Rebel motivation and counterinsurgency in Russia's North Caucasus. *American Political Science Review* 109: 222–38. [CrossRef]

Toft, Monica Duffy, Daniel Philpott, and Timothy S. Shah. 2011. *God's Century: Resurgent Religion and Global Politics*. New York: WW Norton & Company.

Tornielli, Andrea, and Roberto Cetera. 2023. Parolin: Attack on Israel 'inhuman,' legitimate defense should not harm civilians. *Vatican News*.

U.S. Agency for International Development. 2023. *Building Bridges in Development: USAID's Strategic Religious Engagement Policy*. Washington, DC: U.S. Agency for International Development.

Williams, Dodeye Uduak. 2023. Interfaith Dialogue, Peacebuilding, and Sustainable Development in Nigeria: A Case of the Nigeria Inter-Religious Council (NIREC). In *The Palgrave Handbook of Religion, Peacebuilding, and Development in Africa*. Cham: Springer International Publishing, pp. 553–68.

Wilton Park. 2021. *Wilton Park Dialogues on Inclusive Citizenship*. Dialogue Report. Wiston House: Wilton Park.

Wolff, Sarah. 2017. Religious Engagement in the Southern Mediterranean: Much ado about Nothing? In *Mediterranean Politics*. London and New York: Routledge.

Yilmaz, Ihsan, and James Barry. 2020. Instrumentalizing Islam in a 'secular'state: Turkey's diyanet and interfaith dialogue. *Journal of Balkan and Near Eastern Studies* 22: 1–16. [CrossRef]

Zucconi, Cesare. 2018. Beyond Official Negotiations: The Experience of the Community of Sant'Egidio. In *Alternative Approaches in Conflict Resolution*. Edited by Martin Leiner and Christine Schliesser. London: Palgrave MacMillan.

**Disclaimer/Publisher's Note:** The statements, opinions and data contained in all publications are solely those of the individual author(s) and contributor(s) and not of MDPI and/or the editor(s). MDPI and/or the editor(s) disclaim responsibility for any injury to people or property resulting from any ideas, methods, instructions or products referred to in the content.